



Beyond the Curtain: A 10-Day Journey Through the DPRK.

Observations on architecture, culture, and daily life from an exclusive expedition.

June 15–24, 2026 | Organized by Vostokintur

10 Days in the DPRK: A Curator's Field Journal

Firsthand observations across Pyongyang,
Mt. Chilbo, and Rason (June 2026).



Culture & Recreation



The Urban Spectacle (Circus)

High-energy acrobatics, jugglers, and illusionists. A highly emotional, reactive audience filled with cheering youth.



The Ancient Retreat (Mt. Myohyang)

An 11th-century Buddhist temple 170 km from the capital. Defined by serene pine-scented air, rocky waterfalls, and the nearby International Friendship Exhibition.

Journey to the East Coast: Navigating the Fog



1. The Delay

Internal flight to Orang grounded due to heavy coastal fog.

2. The Landscape

Observing meticulous, manicured rice fields through the window—evoking a pristine ‘Swiss Alps’ aesthetic.

3. The Arrival

Plunging directly into a 4km damp, misty hike through the coastal ravines.

Coastal Homestays

Architecture:

Traditional curved-roof structures nestled against the coastal hills.



Sleeping Arrangements:

Futons stored in mirrored cabinets, laid out directly on the heated floors.



The Hosts:

Petite but incredibly strong local women who carry heavy luggage and teach guests the traditional 'Yut' board game.

Climate Control:

Relies on 'Ondol' (traditional underfloor heating) capable of drying soaked hiking gear overnight.

Tastes & Sounds of the East



Sound

The roar of the stormy coastal waves juxtaposed against local guides singing Russian pop hits (Polina Gagarina, Oleg Gazmanov) around the fire.



Taste

Hands-on culinary masterclasses (pounding sweet sticky rice and extruding 'kukusu' glass noodles), followed by dinners of fresh crab, scallops, and sea urchin.

Rason: The Economic Zone



The Rason Zone

Agricultural Ambition: Climate-controlled greenhouse complexes successfully cultivating tropical fruits like bananas and watermelons in the northern DPRK.

Healing Waters: The Kyongsong radon hot springs—a royal retreat since the 15th century, now featuring modern massage facilities and pristine amenities.

Urban Aesthetics: Meticulously maintained floral roundabouts marking the special economic zone.

Youth & Shared Histories

Shared History:

The Chongjin memorial, meticulously maintained, honoring Soviet soldiers who died liberating the region in 1945.



Virtuoso Youth:

A kindergarten performance anchored by a wildly charismatic 5-year-old girl mastering the traditional drum.



Language Exchange: An unscripted session at a foreign language school where tourists practiced basic Russian conversation with eager local students.

The Swiss Illusion: Beyond the Capital

Transit Friction: The internal flight to Orang was abruptly halted and passengers evacuated due to heavy coastal fog, a reminder of the unpredictable environment.

The Landscape: The rigid geometry of the capital gives way to immaculately manicured rice fields and quaint villages bearing a striking resemblance to the Swiss Alps.

Sensory Detail: The air near Mt. Myohyang ("Fragrant Mountain") is thick with the scent of pine needles and mountain flowers.



LAT: 40.015° N, LON: 127.602° E | CLASS: ATMOSPHERIC HAZARD



Cultural Architecture: Life Cycles in the DPRK



Milestone 1: Birth Rituals

For the first 90 days of life, infants are isolated from strangers. A symbol is hung on the door—red pepper for a boy, black coal for a girl—to warn neighbors not to disturb the mother.

Milestone 2: The First Year

The first birthday is a massive milestone, celebrated with a lavish restaurant banquet (similar scale to 60th and 70th birthdays).

Milestone 3: Marriage

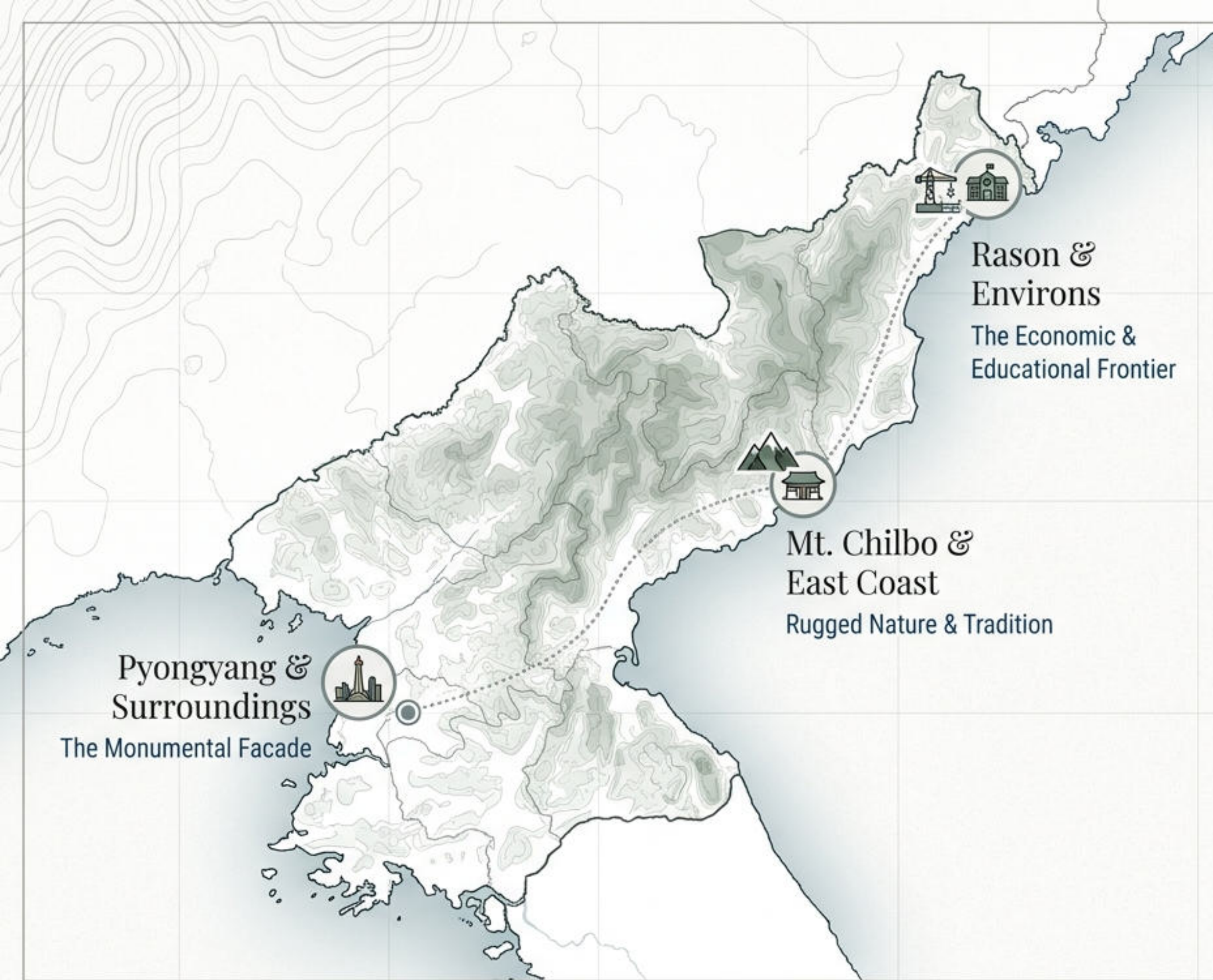
Highly serious and requires strict parental approval. Women generally marry between 24-27. Weddings are massive, ranging from 100 to 300 guests. While legal, divorce is heavily stigmatized by society and the workplace.

The 5-Yuan Spice Order



During a barbecue dinner in Rason, a simple dry meat spice was so delicious that the group asked if they could purchase it. Within hours, custom 100-gram bags were packaged and waiting at the hotel for just 5 Chinese Yuan each.

Takeaway: Alongside state-run souvenir shops selling ginseng and cosmetics, tourists found excellent locally manufactured goods, including high-quality backpacks and school uniform shirts bought straight from a Rason sewing factory.



Pyongyang &
Surroundings
The Monumental Facade

Mt. Chilbo &
East Coast
Rugged Nature & Tradition

Rason &
Environs
The Economic &
Educational Frontier



Expedition Brief

Group Size:
20 Russian tourists

Duration:
10 Days / 9 Nights

Transport:
Internal flights, trams,
mountain hikes